

Codes of Ethics and Professional Conduct

A Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct is a set of simple rules that tells people how to behave properly at work. It is designed to ensure integrity, accountability, and ethical decision-making within an organization or profession.

1. Integrity

Definition: Integrity means being honest and doing the right thing, even when no one is watching or when it's difficult.

Example:

An accountant discovers a small but significant error in financial reporting. Instead of hiding it to protect the company's image, they report it to management and correct the records.

2. Objectivity

Definition: Objectivity means being fair and making decisions based on facts, not personal feelings or bias. It helps professionals stay honest and treat everyone equally.

Example:

An HR manager is interviewing their close friend for a job. To stay fair and avoid giving special treatment, they step away from the hiring team.

3. Professional Competence

Definition: Professional competence means having the right knowledge and skills to do your job well. It also means always learning and improving to stay up to date in your field.

Example:

A software engineer regularly attends workshops and online courses to stay updated with the latest programming languages and cyber-security practices.

4. Confidentiality

Definition: Confidentiality means keeping private information safe and not sharing it with others without permission. It helps build trust and protects people's personal or sensitive data.

Example:

A nurse learns confidential medical information about a celebrity patient and refrains from discussing it, even with close family or friends.

5. Professional Behavior

Definition: Professional behavior means acting respectfully and responsibly at work.

It includes following rules, being polite, and showing a good attitude toward others.

Example:

A worker always arrives on time, dresses neatly, and treats coworkers kindly

6. Respect and Fairness

Definition: Respect and fairness mean treating everyone kindly and equally without favoritism or discrimination. It means listening to others and valuing their opinions and rights.

Example:

A manager ensures that team members from different backgrounds have equal opportunities for training and promotion.

7. Accountability

Definition: Accountability means taking responsibility for your actions and decisions at work. It means admitting mistakes and fixing them without blaming others.

Example:

A project manager admits to missing a deadline and works with the team to find a corrective path, rather than blaming others.

Importance of a Code of Ethics

- Promotes trust and professionalism.
- Minimizes legal risks.
- Enhances company reputation.
- Encourages ethical decision-making.

Importance of Codes of Ethics in Professional Organizations

A Code of Ethics is an important document that explains the expected behavior, values, and duties for people in a profession. It helps keep trust, honesty, and professionalism in the workplace and in society.

1. Builds Trust and Credibility

Explanation:

When professionals follow a clear ethical code, it builds trust with clients, colleagues, and the public. Trust is essential for long-term success.

Example:

A financial advisor gives honest advice focused on what's best for the client, not just making money for themselves. This earns more trust and clients over time.

2. Promotes Professionalism

Explanation:

A Code of Ethics sets clear behavior standards, helping professionals act responsibly and honestly.

Example:

Lawyers don't talk to another lawyer's client without permission, keeping things professional .

3. Guides Decision-Making**Explanation:**

In difficult or unclear situations, a Code of Ethics provides guidance, helping individuals choose the most ethical course of action.

Example:

An IT worker finds a security problem in a client's software and reports it quickly instead of ignoring it.

4. Prevents Misconduct and Legal Issues**Explanation:**

Adhering to ethical standards reduces the risk of unethical behavior, misconduct, and potential legal liabilities.

Example:

A hospital keeps patient information private following its ethical rules, avoiding legal trouble.

5. Enhances Organizational Culture**Explanation:**

A strong ethical code fosters a respectful and fair workplace, encouraging teamwork and accountability.

Example:

An engineering company that does not allow harassment makes a safe place for all workers.

6. Improves Public Image and Reputation**Explanation:**

Organizations known for ethical behavior are more likely to earn public support, media goodwill, and customer loyalty.

Example:

A company that treats workers fairly and sources materials responsibly is liked more by consumers.

7. Ensures Consistency in Behavior

Explanation:

A Code of Ethics provides a consistent framework for employees across departments and levels to behave uniformly.

Example:

A big company makes sure all offices follow the same honesty rules, no matter where they are.

Review of Ethical Codes from Various Professions

Ethical codes are essential in professional fields to ensure responsible, fair, and trustworthy behavior. Different professions tailor their codes of ethics to suit their unique challenges and responsibilities. Below is a review of key ethical codes from prominent professional organizations:

1. IEEE – Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers

Field: Engineering, Technology.

Purpose: Promote safety, honesty, and responsible use of technology.

Core Principles:

- Hold paramount the safety, health, and welfare of the public.
- Avoid real or perceived conflicts of interest.
- Be honest and realistic in stating claims or estimates.
- Improve the understanding of technology and its consequences.

Example:

An engineer working on a self-driving car system identifies a potential safety flaw in the sensor algorithm. According to IEEE's Code of Ethics, they are ethically required to report the issue and prevent harm—even if it delays the product launch.

2. AMA – American Medical Association

Field: Medicine and Healthcare.

Purpose: Ensure ethical patient care, confidentiality, and respect for life.

Core Principles:

- Respect patient autonomy and confidentiality.
- Provide competent medical service with compassion.
- Improve community health.

- Maintain professional competence and honesty.

Example:

A doctor refuses to prescribe medication a patient requests because it's not medically necessary. Instead, the doctor explains alternatives and documents the reasoning—upholding AMA's code of prioritizing patient well-being and medical ethics.

3. ACCA – Association of Chartered Certified Accountants

Field: Accounting and Finance.

Purpose: Ensure financial integrity, transparency, and professional conduct.

Core Principles:

- Integrity
- Objectivity
- Professional competence and due care
- Confidentiality
- Professional behavior

Example:

An accountant at a multinational company is pressured to alter financial figures to boost stock value. Guided by ACCA's code, they refuse and report the issue to an oversight body, maintaining transparency and legality.

4. ACM – Association for Computing Machinery

Field: Computing and Information Technology.

Purpose: Promote responsible computing, protect users' privacy, and avoid harm.

Core Principles:

- Contribute to society and human well-being.
- Avoid harm to others.
- Be honest and trustworthy.
- Respect privacy and confidentiality.
- Ensure fairness and non-discrimination in algorithms.

Example:

A developer discovers that a recruitment algorithm disproportionately filters out candidates from certain backgrounds. Under ACM's ethical code, they halt the rollout and revise the system to eliminate bias.

Summary of Ethical Codes from Major Professions

Organization	Field	Focus of Ethics Code	Notable Areas
IEEE	Engineering, Technology	Safety, honesty, societal impact	Emerging tech, AI responsibility
AMA	Medicine, Healthcare	Patient care, confidentiality, professional behavior	Telemedicine, informed consent
ACCA	Accounting, Finance	Integrity, objectivity, due care	Global financial practices, fraud prevention
ACM	Computing, IT	Respect for privacy, fairness, honesty	Data use, algorithmic fairness, cyber-security

Responsibilities of Professionals to Clients, Employers, and Society

Professionals are trusted to act honestly and responsibly. They must balance their duties to **clients, employers, and society**. Acting ethically helps keep that trust strong.

1. Responsibilities to Clients

Professionals should always do what is **best for the client**, while being **honest, skilled**, and **respectful of privacy**.

Key Responsibilities:

- **Confidentiality:** Keep client information private and safe.
- **Competence:** Only take on work you are trained and qualified to do.
- **Loyalty and Trust:** Avoid conflicts of interest and always act in the client's best interest.
- **Transparency:** Explain costs, risks, and terms clearly.

Example:

A financial advisor suggests safe investments that match the client's needs, **not** ones that give the advisor a higher commission.

2. Responsibilities to Employers

Professionals must **support their company**, act **honestly**, and use resources **wisely**.

Key Responsibilities:

- **Integrity:** Never lie, steal, or commit fraud.
- **Loyalty:** Protect the company's secrets and private information.

- **Efficiency:** Avoid wasting time or money.
- **Accountability:** Take responsibility for your actions.
- **Professionalism:** Be reliable, respectful, and focused on company goals.

Example: An IT manager refuses to use pirated software, even if asked, to avoid breaking the law or harming the company.

3. Responsibilities to Society

Professionals must also **help society**, **protect people**, and **reduce harm** to the environment or others.

Key Responsibilities:

- **Public Safety:** Make sure your work is safe for people and the planet.
- **Fairness and Justice:** Treat all people equally, without discrimination.
- **Environmental Responsibility:** Use eco-friendly practices when possible.
- **Whistleblowing:** Speak up if you see illegal or unethical behavior.

Example:

An engineer finds serious safety problems in a building design. Even though fixing it costs more, they report the issue to prevent accidents and save lives.

Whistleblowing and Confidentiality

Both **confidentiality** and **whistleblowing** are important in professional life. Sometimes they may seem opposite, but both are meant to protect people and encourage ethical behavior.

1. Confidentiality

Definition:

Confidentiality means keeping private or sensitive information secret and not sharing it without permission.

Why It's Important:

- Builds trust between professionals and clients/employers
- Helps follow laws like **GDPR** or **HIPAA**
- Protects personal data and company secrets

Example:

A therapist cannot share what a patient says in therapy unless the patient agrees or someone is in serious danger.

2. Whistleblowing

Definition:

Whistleblowing is when someone reports wrong or harmful actions in a company to someone who can stop it. This might mean breaking confidentiality for a greater good.

Types:

- **Internal Whistleblowing:** Telling a manager or someone inside the company
- **External Whistleblowing:** Reporting to the public, media, or government

Why It's Important:

- Stops harmful or illegal behavior
- Protects people, the environment, or public safety
- Helps make organizations more honest and responsible

Example:

An employee sees their company dumping harmful chemicals in a river. They report it to the environment department, even though it was secret, to protect public safety.

Balancing Confidentiality and Whistleblowing

Sometimes, keeping a secret (confidentiality) and reporting a problem (whistleblowing) conflict. Professionals need to **balance** both duties carefully.

Guidelines for Ethical Whistleblowing:

1. **Try to solve the issue inside the company first.**
2. **Make sure your concern is serious and supported by facts.**
3. **Use proper legal channels if going public.**
4. **Avoid exposing others unless it's absolutely necessary.**

Real-World Scenario

Scenario:

An auditor discovers that a senior executive is embezzling funds. Confidentiality policies discourage discussing client details outside of the firm, but remaining silent may allow continued fraud.

Ethical Action:

The auditor reports the issue to a senior compliance officer (internal whistleblowing). When no action is taken, they contact the regulatory authority (external whistleblowing), backed by documentation.

Comparison Table

Aspect	Confidentiality	Whistleblowing
Definition	Keeping private information secure	Reporting misconduct or danger
Goal	Protect trust and sensitive information	Prevent harm and expose wrongdoing
Risks	Legal liability if breached	Retaliation, job loss, legal action
Ethical Duty	To clients/employers	To public interest and justice
Example	Not sharing patient health records	Reporting unsafe medical practices

Bribe and Gift

The conflict arises when accepting large gifts from the suppliers. Bribe is different from a gift.
The following table shows a comparison of the nature of bribe and gift.

Test	Bribe	Gift
Timing	Given before	Given after
Cost of item	Large amount	Small amount, articles of daily use
Quality of product	Poor	Good/ High
Giver is a friend	Yes	No
Transparency	Made in secret	Made in open
Motive	Expect undue favor	Expect a favor or thanking for the favor
Consequences on organization's goodwill	Damaging the goodwill and reputation	No damage is involved

A bribe is when you give someone money or something valuable to make them do something unfair or dishonest for you. A gift is something you give someone to say "thank you" or show kindness – not to get something in return.